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BREAKING A MOULD Muchi community members at the Shiva temple in Gidhagram, Mar. 12

WEST BENGAL

A WIN AGAINST CASTEISM

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

All her life, Santana Das had watched from a safe distance as others entered the Shiva temple in Gidhagram village in Katwa sub-division in Purba Bardhaman district. Born into the Muchi (cobbler) community—a Dalit group historically excluded from the temple—she had accepted this passively. But, on March 12, wearing her finest saree, she stepped inside for the first time. With her were three women—Pooja Das, Lakshmi Das and Mamata Das—and a man, Shasthi Das, all from the 130 Dalit families in the village. Their entry, under the watchful eye of the local administration, was a declaration of dignity and equality. Later, emerging from the temple after performing the rituals, Santana said, her voice trembling with emotion, "We are elated. I never thought this day would come."

The exclusion of Dalits from temples controlled by privileged castes has been a historical blight in India; conversely, 'temple entry' movements have been the foremost tool to fight entrenched casteism. That such a cycle should be played out in West Bengal—known usually for its liberal social values, besides being under Left rule for 34 years—now is an eye-opener of sorts for many.

Like in other parts of Bengal, caste discrimination in Gidhagram had not always manifested itself openly—members of 'upper castes' openly mingled with Dalits, and other Scheduled Caste groups were permitted entry into the temple. Inexplicably, the Dalit Muchi community alone was excluded, and it took them years to muster the courage to challenge this injustice. This year, members of the community approached the local administration. Ahimsa Jain, the Katwa sub-divisional officer, was taken aback. "I had no idea that such discrimination still persists—especially in a progressive state like Bengal," she tells INDIA TODAY.

AS ELSEWHERE IN BENGAL, DEGREES OF OPENNESS IN SOCIETY KEPT CASTE BIAS LESS THAN TRANSPARENT IN GIDHAGRAM. MUCHIS ALONE WERE BARRED FROM THE TEMPLE

Multiple discussions were held with representatives from all communities and the local panchayat. However, tensions erupted during Shivratri festivities in February, when the Muchi community was denied entry despite the presence of police and administrative officials. Jain says it took more talks and grassroots outreach to persuade the resistant factions. "This long-standing discriminatory practice has been abolished without any law and order complications," she says. Though some members faced threats of socio-economic ostracism, the police have ensured that such retaliation has been curtailed. "From now, all are welcome in the temple," says Nabakumar Ghosh, a privileged caste villager.

However, as Gidhagram gained attention, it opened a can of worms—reports of similar cases emerged from across Bengal. In Nadia's Kaliganj and Purba Bardhaman's Ketugram,